



COMMUNIST LEADERS PAY THEIR LAST RESPECTS TO JYOTI BASU

away as coincidences, but the fact remains that at least three top leaders of the party holding key positions in the Government are unwell: Industries Minister Nirupam Sen, Housing Minister Gautam Deb and Environment Minister Sailen Sarkar. In most cases, the coincidence is not the illnesses but the fact that almost the entire 43-member ministry of Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya is now ageing, with ministers around 65 years the norm than exceptions. In this, Deb stands alone; he is, indeed if that is so, young at 57.

It is this age problem which now haunts the CPI(M) as it braces itself to face the expected onslaught from a dynamic and youthful Opposition headed by Mamata Banerjee. With Assembly elections barely a year away, this could prove disastrous. It is, after all, highly charged, energised foot soldiers, and not ageing generals, who finally have to go out and fight the war. The problem with the CPI(M) is that there are too many ageing generals while the foot soldiers seem to have been swamped by the cry for change.

The simple fact is that the West Bengal unit of the CPI(M), which in the stellar years of the 1970s produced youth icons such as Bhattacharya and now Left Front Chairman Biman Bose, can't boast of a single leader worth his mettle. Under 50, silence rules in the CPI(M) hierarchy.

Minister for Land and Land Reforms Abdur Rejjak Mollah, 68, not one to keep his mouth shut, more so after he was embroiled in the Vedic Village controversy, says, "You need a service check after the guarantee period is over. Leaders don't turn up at your door or drop from trees. You have to allow a leadership to emerge. The CPI(M) leadership doesn't encourage that." The minister further adds, "Babur laid the foundations of the Mughal Empire when he was a teenager. But he was allowed to initiate the process of a new empire building. He was given that space by history and individuals surrounding him."

One of the younger ministers of the state, Abdus Sattar, 40, who looks after the minorities portfolio, says that age is of primary importance in governance. "In order to govern, you need experience and that comes with age. For us communists, there is nothing called retirement and thus we can contribute our utmost till the day we physically can't. Communists do not retire. We do not have personal aspirations. Today, I may be a minister but if tomorrow the party feels I am needed elsewhere, I will go gladly."

A visit to the CPI(M) party office at Alimuddin Street in Kolkata is an eye opener. Even as you wait for Bose to sit for a cup of tea with you, and indulge in banter with the many elderly comrades passing by, the refrain is one and ubiquitous: "Communists mature only by 60. Our party is not the Trinamool that you get senior positions by virtue of influence, you have to slog for it."

Bose, sitting pretty at 70, clarifies the situation. "Look, a member has to move up through four levels: local, zonal, district and state. Such is our party structure. You can't get a berth in the state secretariat fresh from kindergarten, sorry." Bose adds that to become a really senior member or a minister, one has to travel at least 30 years. "So, it is unfair to say that we harbour only oldies. They have earned their positions and unless we have fair reason to do so, there is no question of replacement," he says.

As for illnesses stalking the senior ranks, Bose says, "Mrinal Banerjee worked till his body could not take it. We knew about his cancer. Central Committee member Binoy Konar is pushing 80 but is still active. Subhas (Chakraborty) was extremely active even days before his death. Deb is being treated for a nerve problem. So what do we do? Just throw out these talented comrades because they are old or sick and ignore the fact that they can still put in more work than a man half their age? Sorry, but our party does not function like that."

For the generation which saw the

But he won't be for too long.

In West Bengal, natural home to the communists, the seniority of leaders is never questioned though odd apprehensions are raised at times when an otherwise active sports minister Subhas Chakraborty, 68, suddenly dies of an ailment. Not too many were aware of when power minister Mrinal Banerjee, nursing a cancer which was spreading maliciously, succumbed in his 72nd year. Not to forget the 75-year-old Speaker of the West Bengal Assembly, Hashim Abdul Halim, who fainted and was rushed to an ICU in Singapore. The CPI(M) top brass wishes these events